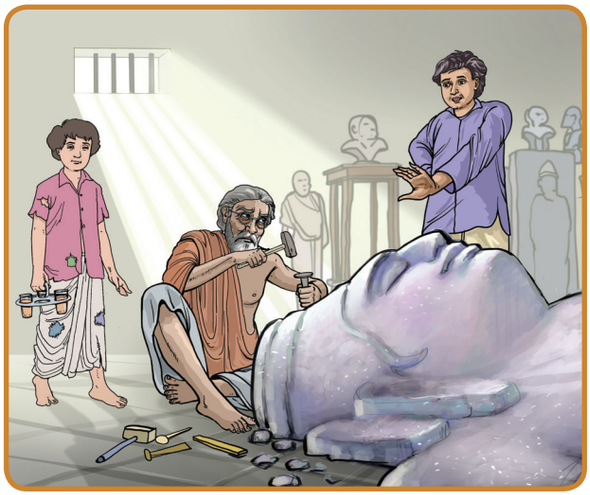
The lines around the man's mouth tightened. "No, my son. This is the work I learnt from my father. And he learned from his father. We have kept up this tradition for hundreds of years... and I hoped you would continue our work."



"No, Father", the young man replied with determination. "I'm tired of working for a pittance for the committee of the temple in Srinagar. I'm leaving, Father."

The young man moved angrily out of the room, leaving his old father **crouching** in front of a half-finished marble statue. He dropped his hands into his laps, and closed his eyes. He began to pray and didn't even hear the hesitant 'goodbye'. His son called out from the door.

"*Masterjee*!" called Salim, the servant boy, entering the workshop barefooted. He held out a glass of steaming tea in his hand. "Masterjee?," he asked once more, his voice filled with concern.

The old man looked up. His face was ashen. He looked tired. He called the boy to come closer and motioned him to sit down.

"Salim," he said gently, "Soon I will be the last stone carver here". All the others would have gone to Agra. There they are turning out cheap candlestands, paperweights and ashtrays by the dozen. They are making money but they betray our skill, our age-old tradition. Now Gopal has also gone. I'll have to finish this sculpture alone. And with the help of God, I'll do it, Salim. "I know you will, Masterjee," the boy answered. "You'll make many more."

The old man looked at the orphan boy who had come to work for him five years ago. Drenched to the skin, dressed in tatters, he had begged for shelter during monsoon storm. And had stayed on to work for the old master craftsman. He had grown tall and strong. The old man knew that Salim too would leave him one day.

He shook his head. "My strength is waning. I can't work with the chisel like I used to. Carving takes too long, much too long." Then he straightened up and said with fresh **determination**, "I'll have to finish this work. And surely I will."

"Yes, you will," the boy repeated offering his master the glass of tea. "Drink please.

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